VELLUM PRESS

FREELANCE & WORK

First Client

A side hustle you can start



A DIGITAL GUIDE

First Client

This is a thirty-day start for a service you can sell beside a job. It does not promise income, and it is not a contract template.

Read your employment agreement before you sell anything near your employer's work. If the clause is unclear, ask someone qualified.

> Work disclaimer. This guide is practical education for starting a small service practice. It is not legal, tax, or employment advice. Contracts, taxes, and conflicts with an existing job depend on where you live and on the agreement you already signed. Have a qualified professional review anything you will sign or file.

Contents

01 How to use this guide
02 An offer someone can buy
03 Pricing without guessing wildly
04 Proof before a big audience
05 Five ways to the first clients
06 Proposals, scope, and deposits
07 Delivery, invoices, and a pipeline
08 Thirty days beside a job
09 A worked example
10 Field pages
11 Thirty-day log

01

How to use this guide

You will leave this PDF with a sentence a stranger can buy, a floor price, and five conversations. You will not leave it with a logo. Design the offer before the identity.

- One service, not a menu.
- A floor price written down.
- A deposit rule.
- Two weekly blocks that end.

02

An offer someone can buy

An offer names the buyer, the problem, the thing they hold when you are done, and what you will not do. 'I help people with marketing' is not an offer. 'I write the monthly email and one landing page for independent clinics' is an offer. The non-example matters: if you cannot say what is out of scope, the project will expand into your evenings.

- [ ] The buyer is specific enough to exclude people.
- [ ] The outcome is a thing, not 'support.'
- [ ] The number of revision rounds is a number.
- [ ] I can say who this is not for.

> **Try this.** Read the sentence aloud to someone who does not do your job. If they cannot repeat it, it is not finished.

03

Pricing without guessing wildly

Estimate hours including email and revisions. Multiply by a rate that respects taxes and the fact that you cannot do this for forty hours while employed. That product is the floor. Work below the floor is a no, not a discount that eats a weekend.

Number	How you get it	Use
Floor	Hours times a survivable rate, plus costs	The walk-away
Target	Floor plus the value of a clear outcome	What you quote
Ceiling	The point where scope must change	When you re-quote

Quote a price for the outcome, not an open hourly meter, unless the work truly cannot be scoped. An open meter trains the client to watch the clock and trains you to feel guilty for thinking.

> This is not advice about what your market will pay. It is a way to stop inventing a number in the email.

04

Proof before a big audience

You do not need a following. You need proof that you can do the thing: a before-and-after from your own job with confidential details removed, a sample made for a fictional brief, or a short paid pilot. Ask permission before you show an employer's work. When in doubt, make a sample that is clearly yours.

Three pieces of proof are enough to start the conversations. Ten pieces are a portfolio project that delays the ask.

05

Five ways to the first clients

• Former colleagues who already trust your work. One clear email, not a manifesto.

• A local or professional association where the buyer complains about this problem.

• A specific person who serves the same buyer and does not do what you do. Offer a referral, not a partnership fantasy.

• A past client from any smaller job, asked whether the next version would help.

• One relevant community, with a useful answer first and the offer second.

Send five of these in the first two weeks. Track them. A conversation is not a client. A paid deposit is a client.

> **Try this.** The email is six sentences: who you are, the offer, the proof, the price range or the next step, and a question. Then stop writing.

06

Proposals, scope, and deposits

A proposal fits on one page: outcome, what is included, what is not, timeline in business days you can actually hit, price, and how you get paid. Ask for a deposit before you start. Half to begin and half on delivery is a common pattern for small jobs. Full payment up front is reasonable when the job is small.

Do not copy a contract from the internet and send it. Use a checklist with a qualified professional: who owns the work, what happens if they disappear, how revisions work, and how either of you can end it. Your employment agreement may already limit outside work. Read it.

- ☐ Outcome described as a deliverable.
- ☐ Exclusions written.
- ☐ Dates that match my real blocks.
- ☐ Deposit stated.
- ☐ A person qualified to review the agreement, if money or risk is real.

07

Delivery, invoices, and a pipeline

Deliver on the date you named. Send the invoice the same day, with the payment method and the due date. A pipeline is a list: name, last contact, next step, date. If the next step is 'someday,' you do not have a pipeline.

Stage	Meaning	Next step is
Talk	They understand the offer	Send the one-pager
Proposal	Price and scope are written	Ask for the deposit
Active	Deposit is in	Do the work inside the blocks
Done	Delivered and paid	Ask if a next version helps

> Taxes on side income are real and local. Set aside a portion of every payment in a separate place so the bill is not a surprise. This PDF will not tell you the rate. A tax preparer or your revenue agency will.

08

Thirty days beside a job

Days	Work	Hours
1 to 3	Write the offer and the floor price	Two evenings
4 to 7	Make or gather three proofs	One weekend block
8 to 14	Send five outreaches	Three short sessions
15 to 21	Have the conversations. Send one proposal.	Two evenings
22 to 30	Decide: continue, change the sentence, or stop	One review

Stopping is a result. An endless 'I am still working on it' is how the job you already have loses its evenings. Do not quit because one person sounded interested. Interest is not an invoice.

> **Try this.** Put the two blocks on the calendar before day 1. A plan that waits for free time will meet a month with none.

09

A worked example

F is employed as an in-house designer and wanted freelance branding work, which is a fog. The offer became: a one-page menu and a simple poster template for independent cafes, delivered in ten business days, two revision rounds, not a full identity system. The floor price came from twelve honest hours.

F checked the employment agreement before sending anything. A clause restricted work for competitors. Cafes were not competitors. F still asked the person at work who answers that question, and kept the email. Proof was a sample for a fictional cafe, not the employer's files.

Five outreaches went to former classmates and one local roaster F already knew. Two replied. One became a proposal. The deposit arrived in week 4, which is the first time the side hustle was real. The other conversation stayed a compliment. Compliments are not a pipeline stage.

Day 30, F decided to continue for another thirty days with the same offer, not a wider one. The evenings were two blocks, and they ended. Taxes were a separate account, a percentage set aside, and a note to ask a preparer before filing. The guide did not find the client. The sentence and the five emails did.

If your week does not look like this one, do not force the resemblance. Copy the structure: a baseline, one change at a time, a written review, and a stop when the tool is the wrong tool. The names above are teaching composites, not testimonials and not promises.

10

Field pages

Fill the offer before you design anything visual. If a box is vague, the email you send will be vague.

The offer

Box	Write it in one sentence
Buyer	
Problem	
What they hold at the end	
What is not included	
Floor price	
Target price	

Pipeline

Name	Stage	Last contact	Next step	Date
1				
2				

Name	Stage	Last contact	Next step	Date
3				
4				
5				

- ☐ Employment agreement checked.
- ☐ Deposit rule written.
- ☐ Five outreaches sent or scheduled.
- ☐ Day 30 decision: continue, change the sentence, or stop.

11

Thirty-day log

This log is the part you write. Print it. A guide you only read is a brochure. Thirty lines is a month, and a month is long enough to see whether the method fits.

Days 1 to 15

Day	Outreach	Reply	Money	Hours	Note
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					
7					
8					
9					
10					
11					
12					
13					

Day	Outreach	Reply	Money	Hours	Note
14					
15					

Do not backfill a day you forgot. Leave it blank. A blank line is more useful next month than a number you invented. The lines are tall enough to write in, not just to type a checkmark.

Days 16 to 30

Day	Outreach	Reply	Money	Hours	Note
16					
17					
18					
19					
20					
21					
22					
23					
24					
25					
26					
27					
28					
29					
30					

Weekly notes

Week	What repeated	What I will change
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

Open notes

	Write in the lines

	Write in the lines

End of the month

Question	Your answer
What actually repeated?	
What did I abandon, and should it stay abandoned?	
What is the one change for next month?	
Do I need a person, not a PDF?	
Where is the file saved on my own device?	

- ☐ I can find this PDF without the download link.
- ☐ The license is mine. I have not posted the file.
- ☐ Next month's first action is written in one sentence.
- ☐ If the guide was the wrong tool, I know what I will do instead.

A last word

Use the pages that match the week you are actually having. Print a worksheet if paper helps you tell the truth. Put the file somewhere you can find it. And if a chapter tells you to talk to a licensed professional, that instruction outranks the rest of the PDF.